cranes and vultures to trees and watercourses. This protectionism has led them to lock horns with the powerful. Radheshyam is the latest martyr of their righteous war.

A commemorative cenotaph stands at Khejarli near Jodhpur, which draws its name from the khejri (*Prosopis cineraria*), Rajasthan's state tree whose munificent shade offers succour from the desert sun. Here, in 1730, centuries before Chipko made tree-hugging emblematic of environmentalism, Amrita Devi embraced a khejri to prevent it from being axed by a local maharaja's men. For daring to resist, the mother and her three daughters were hacked to death. Another 360 Bishnoi joined their sacrifice, which went down in history as the Khejarli massacre.

> Travelling around Rajasthan, **Goodman meets many eco-warriors. The narrative** is a sequence of essays and profiles

Goodman's book, written with Bishnoi blessings, begins with this story. Travelling around Rajasthan, he conversed with people—Radheshyam who saved bustards from colliding with power lines, young Pooja who nurses orphaned chinkaras back to health, Ranaram who plants trees to repel the invading desert, and others. Interspersed with Franck Vogel's monochrome photographs, the narrative is a sequence of enquiring essays and profiles.

What should have been a flawless book is riddled with an insouciance for facts. The Demoiselle Crane is conflated with the Sarus Crane, the *kraun-cha pakshi* of Valmiki's Ramayana. Marwari is misidentified as a dialect of Hindi. Well-known names are misspelled. Despite such foibles, this book has an urgent message for our generation's climate anxiety: though one cannot be born Bishnoi, one can draw upon the sect's credo of living by one's conscience.

"This body is born and it perishes," Jambhoji warned. In the aftermath of Khejarli, the king relented; the trees were spared. Amid the juggernaut of development in Rajasthan, trees are lost, grasslands destroyed, and wildlife sentenced to death. As the Bishnoi keep a body count, their battles endure and so do their sacrifices. ■

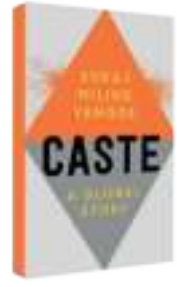
—Bijoy Venugopal



PICTURING PLACE
Painted and Printed Maps at the Udaipur Court
By Shailka Mishra
MAHARANA OF MEWAR CHARITABLE FOUNDATION
176 pages

CHARTING THE PAST

Based on an exhibition of rare maps of Udaipur and Mewar held at the City Palace Museum in Udaipur, this catalogue brings together maps and miniatures from medieval to modern times. Most prominent are riveting archival photos of Mewar, including an album documenting the construction of railways in the princely state.



CASTE: A GLOBAL STORY
by Suraj Milind Yengde
PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE
₹899; 360 pages

CASTING A SHADOW

Set to hit Indian bookstores by June-end, this groundbreaking study of Dalit lives examines how caste and caste-based discrimination are experienced around the world. Based on 10 years of research, it spans 15 countries and trains its lens on everything, from 19th-century indentured labourers in the Caribbean to modern-day migrant workers in the Middle East.

KEEPING THE FAITH

This new anthology of queer writing from South Asia focuses on the fraught intersection of queerness and faith. Addressing identity and belonging through poetry, memoir and flash fiction, it brings together 24 LGBTQIA+ writers who conjure up worlds which are either fantastical or painfully real.

ON THE BRINK OF BELIEF
Edited by Kazim Ali
PENGUIN
₹499; 264 pages



—Compiled by Amit Dixit